MODULE-1 · MASTERCLASS DOSSIER

1.3 The Proof Stack

Lesson masterclass · implementation drills · war-room directive

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Build a market-weighted evidence vault of third-party receipts.
- Separate first-party proof from borrowed credentials.
- Create per-market proof shelves so every pitch shows local proof.

★ **INSIDER RADIO TIP**

Proof is market-weighted — a spin in the target's metro outranks 100k global streams. Tag every receipt with a market and build per-market proof shelves. Never show Austin receipts in a Boston pitch.

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1.3 The Proof Stack — Build the Evidence Vault That Makes PDs Say Yes

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THE ONE-LINE TRUTH: Nobody risks airtime on enthusiasm. The Proof Stack is your third-party credibility vault — transforming subjective musical taste into undeniable objective evidence.

MASTERCLASS DIRECTIVE & STRATEGIC BLUEPRINT

Strategic Foundation & Operational Reality

When a music programmer opens your submission, they apply a subconscious heuristic: "Can I justify playing this record to my General Manager, my consulting network, and my listeners if it fails?"

If your pitch relies exclusively on your personal conviction—"This is my best song yet, you will love it"—the programmer bears 100% of the downside risk. But when your pitch cites verifiable third-party receipts —"Already spinning on KEXP night rotation, 15,000 regional Shazams in target metro, headlined Bowery Ballroom with 400 tickets sold"—the risk transfers from the programmer to the objective market evidence.

This is the purpose of the **Proof Stack**. You do not build a career on potential; potential is an empty promise. You build dominion on receipts. Every review, spin, sold-out gig, playlist inclusion, editorial quote, and industry endorsement is a negotiable asset.

The Five Tiers of Proof Architecture

Screeners and programmers evaluate evidence through a rigid credibility hierarchy:

- **S-Tier (Institutional Authority):** Terrestrial broadcast adds on recognized non-comm / AAA / college flagships (e.g., KEXP, KCRW, WXPN, The Current), charting positions on NACC Top 200 or Americana

Singles Charts, and verified sync placements in major film/TV. An S-tier receipt virtually guarantees a listening evaluation.

- **A-Tier (Market Momentum):** Verifiable live concert ticket sales in the target station's metro (minimum 150+ tickets), regional press coverage from respected publications, and verified high-engagement editorial playlist inclusions.
- **B-Tier (Digital Traction):** Organic algorithmic streaming spikes, localized Shazam clustering in specific zip codes, and clean social video traction with high comment-to-view ratios.
- **C-Tier (Ambient Signal):** Local blog features, amateur podcast interviews, and general follower counts. These provide minor color but never lead a serious broadcast pitch.
- **D-Tier (Anti-Proof — Eliminate Immediately):** Pay-to-play blog placements, botted Spotify playlist placements, purchased social follower spikes, and screenshots of mom or friends saying the song is a smash. Programmers spot fabricated traction in 3 seconds.

Assembling the Four-Line Pitch Proof Stack

In your direct communications, you will never overwhelm a gatekeeper with a 10-page press kit. You will distill your strongest evidence into a razor-sharp **Four-Line Proof Stack**:

1. Line 1 (Broadcast / Institutional): "Spinning in rotation on WXPN & KUTX specialty blocks."
2. Line 2 (Live / Regional Ground Game): "280 tickets sold at Metro Chicago; upcoming Lincoln Hall date."
3. Line 3 (Traction / Metric Velocity): "1,200 regional Shazams centered in Cook County over 14 days."
4. Line 4 (Critical Validation): "'A blistering return to Midwest indie rock' — Chicago Reader."

If you currently lack S-Tier broadcast receipts, you do not despair. You harvest what you currently possess—live ticket numbers, local press, hometown support—and use those receipts to secure your first college add. That college add becomes the S-Tier receipt that unlocks regional commercial specialty shows.

IMPLEMENTATION DRILLS & PASS STANDARDS

- **Drill 1 — The Deep Receipt Excavation (45 min).** Mine your email history, ticketing accounts, DSP analytics, and press archives. Extract at least 10 concrete proof receipts and classify them using the Proof Stack Inventory below.
- **Drill 2 — The Four-Line Proof Stack Construction (20 min).** Assemble your best four lines of proof. Ensure each line represents a distinct proof vector (institutional, live, velocity, press).
- **Drill 3 — Anti-Proof Scrubbing Protocol (15 min).** Review your EPK, social bios, and pitch drafts. Ruthlessly delete every vague, unprovable claim ('buzzing artist', 'taking the city by storm', 'next big thing') and replace with documented facts.
- **Drill 4 — The 7-Day Proof Manufacture Mission (15 min).** Identify your single weakest proof tier. Schedule one tangible operational action within the next 7 days to manufacture a legitimate receipt (e.g., booking a specific venue date, submitting to college press, pitching a local specialty DJ).

ACTION WORKSHEET & OPERATIONAL PROTOCOL

Protocol Document: `PROOF STACK INVENTORY & CREDIBILITY CLASSIFIER`

Complete the structured table below as part of your lesson implementation. This worksheet directly replaces legacy spreadsheets with a publication-grade execution protocol.

Receipt Description	Proof Tier	Date Verified	Source / Authority	Strategic Deployment Context
Station add on WNUR 89.3 FM (Chicago)	S-Tier (Broadcast)	Current Quarter	Station Airplay Log / Spinitron	Lead proof point for regional Midwest college push
220 tickets sold @ Thalia Hall showcase	A-Tier (Live Market)	Last Month	Ticketmaster / Eventbrite statement	Cite in tour-corridor pitches to Milwaukee/Detroit
2,400 organic Spotify saves within 21 days	B-Tier (Traction)	Current Cycle	Spotify for Artists Analytics	Demonstrate listener retention in follow-up emails

Featured review in Under The Radar	A-Tier (Press)	Two Months Ago	Editorial Column Link	Quote one sharp sentence in EPK header block
Upcoming supporting slot for national act	A-Tier (Co-Sign)	Confirmed Date	Official Venue Announce Poster	Create urgent time-stamped news hook for pitch

WAR-ROOM NOTES

WAR-ROOM DIRECTIVE — 1.3 The Proof Stack — Build the Evidence Vault That Makes PDs Say Yes

PROOF IS MARKET-WEIGHTED: THE HYPER-LOCAL RECEIPT PRINCIPLE

The most common mistake artists make when pitching regional stations is citing national or disconnected international metrics. If you are pitching a Seattle station (such as KEXP), 500 local Seattle ticket buyers or 50 spins on a neighboring Washington college station (like KUGS in Bellingham) carries 10x more psychological weight than 500,000 passive streams in Germany.

THE PROOF ACCELERATION LADDER:

1. **The College Foothold:** College and community radio stations (Class D and non-comm educational) do not operate under commercial ratings terror. They exist to curate adventurous new sounds. Securing adds on three regional college stations provides the verifiable broadcast proof needed to approach secondary commercial stations.
2. **The Spinitron Paper Trail:** Always track station play logs via Spinitron or station online playlists. Take clean, timestamped screenshots showing your artist name and song title in the official log. A screenshot of an official log is unassailable proof.
3. **Never Lead with Social Follower Counts:** Music directors know follower counts are frequently bought or passive. Lead with verified engagement, physical attendance, and broadcast rotation.

FREQUENCY DOMINION COMMUNITY DRILLS

1. Post your Four-Line Proof Stack for peer review. Group members will grade it for punch, credibility, and fluff.
2. Share the single strongest receipt you uncovered during your excavation drill.
3. What specific 7-day action are you taking this week to manufacture your next S-Tier or A-Tier proof receipt?
4. Identify an anti-proof phrase you previously used in pitches that you have permanently retired today.

Key Takeaways

REMEMBER THIS

- Third-party evidence transfers risk.
- Proof is market-weighted — a metro spin outranks global streams.
- Per-market shelves beat one global deck.

Self-Assessment · Check Your Mastery

PASS BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- 1. Do I hold at least one verifiable receipt per target market?
- 2. Is every receipt tagged with a market, not just a date?
- 3. Can I show local proof for every local pitch I send?